

Frame Free

Frame the decision before AI answers it.

Upload this PDF into Claude, ChatGPT or Gemini with one live business decision. It will ask six questions, one at a time, and stop before evaluation.

Start with: Use Frame Free in this PDF. Ask me one question at a time.

THE SIX QUESTIONS

1 The decision and trigger

What exactly are you deciding, and what made it live now?

2 The decision underneath

If the immediate choice disappeared, what larger question would remain?

3 The missing option

Which genuine third path have you not treated as real, including doing nothing?

4 The load-bearing assumption

Which single belief would change the decision if it proved wrong?

5 Untested constraints

Which deadlines, budgets or stakeholder positions are verified, and which are assumed?

6 The evidence map

What is GIVEN, DERIVED, INFERRED or UNKNOWN? Keep approximations visible.

FINISH WITH

A reframed decision; the missing third path; the load-bearing assumption; constraints marked verified or assumed; an evidence map; and the single evidence gap to verify next.

STOP RULE Do not rank options, score criteria or recommend a course of action.

Why framing comes before evaluation

Most decision tools begin after the question has already been framed. Frame Free starts one step earlier.

Prompt packs, pros-and-cons lists, decision matrices and 2x2s all start weighing options. That can produce a rigorous answer to the wrong question. Frame Free interrogates the decision itself first.

The most expensive error is answering the presented question correctly when the real decision sits underneath it. Ten minutes of framing is inexpensive insurance against that error.

For the AI reading this file

- 1 Ask the user for one live decision and its trigger. If they supplied both with the upload, confirm them briefly.
- 2 Ask the six questions in order, one at a time. Do not reveal all six as a questionnaire.
- 3 Challenge vague categories, unsupported certainty and constraints that have not been verified.
- 4 Use at most one focused follow-up per question so the frame remains usable in about ten minutes.
- 5 Preserve the user's language where it is precise. Do not invent facts, options, owners, dates or confidence.
- 6 Finish with the seven-part framing handoff shown below, then stop before evaluation or advice.

FRAMING HANDOFF

1. Presented decision and trigger
2. Decision underneath
3. Missing third option
4. Load-bearing assumption
5. Untested constraints - each marked VERIFIED or ASSUMED
6. Evidence map - each material claim marked GIVEN, DERIVED, INFERRED or UNKNOWN
7. Reframed decision and the single evidence gap to verify next

Stop here. Framing prepares a decision; it does not make the decision.

Find the question behind the question

The first three moves make the decision explicit, expose the deeper issue and reopen the option set.

1 What exactly are you deciding, and what triggered it now?

State the decision in one sentence. Name what made it live today rather than last month.

Why it matters. Most stalled decisions were never actually stated. Until the decision has a trigger, you may be analysing a mood rather than a choice.

Sharpen it. If the answer is a category such as growth, efficiency or transformation, turn it into a measurable scenario. Then ask why it is active now.

2 What is the decision underneath this one?

If the immediate choice disappeared, what larger question would still be sitting there?

Why it matters. People often argue about the surface choice while avoiding the real one. The presented question is frequently a symptom of a deeper decision.

Sharpen it. Ask whether this is the problem or a means. If the answer names a means such as 'be more innovative', push through to the outcome it is meant to change.

3 Which option is missing?

Name a genuine third path you have not been treating as real, including keeping the current position.

Why it matters. A two-option list is usually inherited, not built. Someone framed it as A or B before it reached you, and that framing may carry more authority than it earned.

Sharpen it. The third path must be credible enough to take seriously later. 'Do nothing for six months' and 'A, but half the size' both count. Do not evaluate it yet.

Separate evidence from assumption

The final three moves identify the belief carrying the decision, test what has been treated as fixed and make the evidence state visible.

4 What is the one assumption the whole decision rests on?

Find the single belief that, if wrong, changes everything. Not a list of risks - the load-bearing one.

Why it matters. Long risk lists spread attention thin. One belief usually carries more weight than the others and deserves to be named before anything is evaluated.

Sharpen it. Finish: 'This decision makes sense provided that ...' Then ask what has actually been seen, measured or verified in support.

5 Which of your facts are actually assumptions?

Take each constraint treated as fixed - deadline, budget, policy, capacity or stakeholder position - and mark it verified or assumed.

Why it matters. An untested constraint quietly deletes real options before evaluation. Reclassifying one can change the decision more than another analytical tool.

Sharpen it. Ask who set it, when it was last tested and how you would know if it moved. 'The deadline is fixed' often means nobody has asked.

6 What do you actually know?

Tag each material claim so the honest evidence map is visible. Put any approximation inside the claim rather than inventing another label.

Why it matters. Most briefs do not show which parts are known and which are guessed. The map makes the framing inspectable when another person challenges it.

Sharpen it. Use one taxonomy and nothing else: GIVEN, DERIVED, INFERRED or UNKNOWN.

Tag	Meaning	Sounds like
GIVEN	Directly supplied or verified	'The contract says ...'
DERIVED	Calculated from given information	'That works out to ...'
INFERRED	Reasoned from what is known	'If churn holds, then ...'
UNKNOWN	Material but not established	Competitor intent; untested belief

The software was the surface

An operations manager at a 60-person home-services business is told to choose between two rostering platforms before the current contract expires.

■ Presented decision	Choose vendor A or vendor B by the end of the month. The trigger is a renewal notice.
■ Decision underneath	Rosters are rebuilt by hand every week because the shift rules keep changing. The real question is what those rules should be.
■ Missing third option	Extend the current contract month to month, fix the roster rules first, then choose software against stable requirements.
■ Load-bearing assumption	'The pain is the software.' If the pain is the rules, even the best platform changes nothing.
■ Untested constraints	The deadline is treated as fixed, but the vendor offers month-to-month extensions. The \$40k budget cap was set two years ago and has not been retested.
■ Evidence map	GIVEN: current licence cost; rosters are rebuilt weekly. DERIVED: about 15 hours a week are lost to manual fixes. INFERRED: some turnover traces to roster chaos. UNKNOWN: whether award compliance is exposed.
■ Reframed decision	Verify the extension, stabilise the shift rules, then choose tooling against those rules.
■ Evidence gap to test next	Confirm whether an award-compliance exposure already exists. If it does, the timing and scope of the next step change.

No options were scored. Nothing was recommended. The question became the right one - which is the point.

Framed is not decided

Use these extra lenses only when the six questions do not produce a clean frame. Then decide whether the work needs a full comparison.

If the frame is still stuck

Decision type	Growth, turnaround, operating model, investment, transformation or risk mitigation.
Evidence level	Data-poor, data-mixed or data-rich. Data-poor calls need harder assumption tagging, not more confidence.
Stakeholder dynamic	Aligned, partially aligned or actively conflicted. Conflict may require a stakeholder map before evaluation.
Time horizon	Urgent, near-term, medium-term or long-term. Separate what must be decided now from what can wait.

PRESSURE SCAN

- What competitive or market shift is touching this decision now?
- What is the largest internal constraint?
- What happens if the hardest deadline is missed?
- Whose expectations are hardest to manage, and why?
- What regulatory or compliance exposure matters?
- What system dependency or financial limit could reshape the frame?

Frame Pro begins where Frame Free stops.

Frame Free clarifies the question. Frame Pro continues it into deeper interrogation, credible options, explicit criteria, comparison, a recommendation and a five-part Decision Brief. Frame Pro is in development. Its scope, price and support terms will be published together before it is offered for purchase.

ASK - FRAME - CONFIRM - COMPARE - RECOMMEND

[See the complete process](#)
[Review the evidence and limitations](#)